

SYLLABUS: PHI 101 BASIC ISSUES IN PHILOSOPHY

DAVID SANSON
PHI101

Instructor

David Sanson

Class Meetings

PHI 101-003 [Honors] MW 3:35PM – 4:50PM, Stevenson 0229

PHI 101-002, MW 5:00PM – 6:15PM, Stevenson 0121

Office Hours

Stevenson 341, TBA

COURSE DESCRIPTION

This is a course about doing philosophy. We will spend the next 15 weeks doing philosophy together.

Why? Because doing philosophy is pretty neat. Essentially, doing philosophy is a matter of thinking as clearly and carefully as possible, about anything and everything. Most fields of study are constrained either in their subject or their method, or both. Chemists use empirical methods to study chemicals. English Literature uses a variety of techniques to study literary texts. Mathematics uses abstract reasoning to study mathematical objects like numbers, shapes, and sets.

In philosophy, we are open to asking questions about anything, and we are not tied to any particular methods of investigation. To the extent we have a method, it is this: try to get as clear as possible about the question we are asking, try to get as clear as possible about how that question might be answered, and then try to figure out what can be said for and against different answers.

Sometimes, we end up discovering that certain questions are best answered using certain methods. For example, we discovered that certain questions about matter and motion were best answered using quantitative mathematical methods along with certain sorts of physical observations and experiments. That's how "physics" came to exist as a field separate from philosophy: the philosophers interested in those questions learned to specialize in those methods, and restricted their attention to the kinds of questions that can be answered using such methods.

The questions we will tackle in this course are fundamental questions about existence, knowledge, morality, and society. The broader culture often encourages us to dismiss such questions. We are told that they have no correct answers and are beyond the reach of reason and evidence; or that they are the domain of religious belief or secular opinion, and it is rude to express disagreement about such things; or that they are childish questions that serious adults should put aside in favor of more immediate practical concerns.

Those are all interesting philosophical claims that raise interesting questions: How could it be that fundamental questions about existence, knowledge, morality, and society simply had no correct answers? Why should it be rude to question religious beliefs, when many religious beliefs appear to be making substantive claims about the world and our place in it? What are these practical concerns that adults are supposed to focus on, and what makes them more important than other things?

Each week, we will consider one controversial answer to a specific philosophical question. Our textbook will present an argument in defense of that answer. For example, chapter one presents an argument against the existence of God, while chapter two presents an argument that you should believe in God even if there is no good evidence that she exists. We will work through these arguments carefully, and try to assess their strength. If you think an argument is weak, you

will be pressed to clarify exactly where and how you think it goes wrong. If you think an argument is strong, you will be pressed to respond to these objections, and clarify exactly where and how you think they go wrong.

Here are the topics we will cover: Does God exist? Should you believe in God? What makes you you? Is death bad? Do you have free will? What can we know about the world? Does the government have the moral authority to put people in prison, collect taxes, or restrict immigration? Is abortion immoral? Is eating animals immoral? What makes an action moral or immoral?

TODO: add more topics after writing additional chapters.

GRADES AND ASSIGNMENTS

EXAMS

IN-CLASS WORK

EXTRA CREDIT ASSIGNMENTS

ATTENDANCE

You are responsible for attending class and completing all assigned academic work. You should familiarize yourself with University policy to understand which absences are excused and which are not. If you need advice on how to manage an extended absence or want notification of your absence sent to your instructors, contact the Dean of Students Office.

CONSEQUENCES OF ABSENCE

Formally, absence will impact your ability to earn points from in-class work. Informally, absence deprives you of the opportunity to learn from lecture and discussion. This is true both for excused and unexcused absences.

ACCOMMODATIONS

Any student needing to arrange a reasonable accommodation for a documented disability and/or medical/mental health condition should contact Student Access and Accommodation Services at 308 Fell Hall, Office Phone (309) 438-5853, Video Phone (309) 319-7682 or visit the website at <StudentAccess.IllinoisState.edu>.

I am also open to arranging reasonable accommodation regardless of documentation. If there is something you need, ask.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

You are expected to be honest in all academic work, consistent with the academic integrity policy as outlined in the Code of Student Conduct and any additional syllabus language. All work is to be appropriately cited when it is borrowed,

directly or indirectly, from another source. Unauthorized and/or unacknowledged collaboration on any work, or the presentation of someone else's work as your own, is a form of academic dishonesty under the Code of Student Conduct.

Content generated by an Artificial Intelligence third-party service or site (AI-generated content) without proper authorization and attribution is a form of academic dishonesty. If you are unsure about whether something used in your work requires attribution, please reach out to me to discuss it as soon as possible. Allegations of academic dishonesty will be referred to Student Conduct and Community Responsibilities, for review under the Student Code of Conduct. Students found responsible for academic dishonesty may also be assigned a grade penalty by the instructor.

GENERATIVE AI USE NOT PERMITTED

In this course, the use of generative AI tools such as ChatGPT, Microsoft Copilot, Adobe Firefly, Google AI Mode, or Apple Intelligence is not permitted to support the completion of any assigned work. This includes, but is not limited to, using generative AI tools to ideate, pre-plan, edit, translate, or otherwise create original material you claim to be solely your creation. Use of a generative AI tool to complete assigned work in whole or in part may be referred under the Code of Student Conduct academic dishonesty provisions for further action by the Dean of Students Office.

PERMISSION REQUIRED TO RECORD

Students who wish to use phones or other audio or video devices to record classroom lectures/discussions or take photographs must obtain written permission from the instructor except with an approved accommodation from Student Access and Accommodations Services. Approved recordings are to be used solely for the purposes of individual or group study with other students enrolled in the class. They may not be reproduced, shared with those not enrolled in the class, or uploaded to publicly accessible web environments. Violation of this classroom rule may result in referral to the Student Conduct and Community Responsibilities (SCCR) office for disciplinary action.